

I would have defined Smith Street as the ‘forgotten’ street of inner Melbourne – because it sort of was. And it stayed that way until four or so years ago. I didn’t really care where I lived, but needed a house with a backyard as I had a German shepherd to accommodate. Location really was not at the top of my list; I just had a gigantic circle on a map of Melbourne.

I had been the underbidder on about five properties at auction in different suburbs. It was driving me crazy. One day, between inspection times in houses I was looking at in Richmond, I took myself up to a Collingwood open house to fill in some time. When I went into the house I was completely charmed by it, but thought I’d never afford it, and that it was just heavily underquoted.

A couple of weeks later I was on vacation in Florence with a friend, and we’d been enjoying the local wine. We were chatting about houses and Collingwood came up, and at some ungodly hour in the evening I rang up and made an offer on the house, which they accepted. It was before the auction, and I probably paid too much. We celebrated with more wine, and it wasn’t until the next day at around lunchtime that I remembered buying it. True story.

Anderson’s manner of buying – after a night on the sauce during a European getaway – isn’t advisable, but his open-mindedness is. His faith in a suburb that was not popular has paid off. The median house price in Collingwood now hovers around \$1 million, according to Domain Group data, and it is a similar story across Australia. It’s a lesson that suburbs change through the years, and so too will the suburbs that first home buyers can afford right now. From Redfern and Erskineville in Sydney, to Brisbane’s Fortitude Valley and Croydon in Adelaide, these suburbs have humble roots but have been transformed – gentrified – into a prestigious patch of real estate after a bit of hipster spit and polish.

If you can believe it, the number of tattoo parlours – not the volume of swish brunches served on a weekend – can be a factor as to whether a suburb is gentrifying, and therefore desirable. Microburbs (microburbs.com.au) is a data science website created